

Measurement

POL 51: Scientific Study of Politics

Spring 2026

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 - ▶ **Psychology**: Depression, anxiety, prejudice

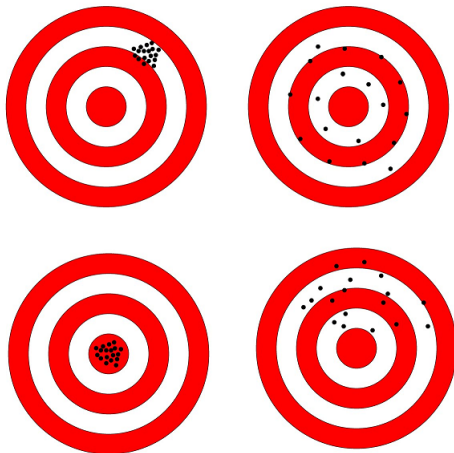
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- ▶ Even concepts that look straightforward can be difficult. Example: partisanship.
- ▶ **Operationalization**: moving from abstract concepts to empirical measures.

Accuracy of Measurement

- ▶ **Reliability**: the extent to which the measurement technique yields the same results when repeated.
- ▶ **Validity**: the extent to which the measurement measures of captures the underlying concept.

Accuracy of Measurement



Assessing Reliability

- ▶ Test-retest method
- ▶ Split-halves method

Example: Democracy

- ▶ What does it mean to say that a country is more or less democratic?
- ▶ Robert Dahl emphasizes **contestation** and **participation**
- ▶ Independent judiciary/press, separation of powers, economic freedom?

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- ▶ Example: political ideology

- ▶ How do we assign/interpret the values assigned to concepts?

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- ▶ Three levels:
 1. **Categorical**: region, religion, etc.
 2. **Ordinal**: party identification, strongly disagree-strongly agree questions.
 3. **Continuous**: equal unit differences: age, percentages.

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$$\text{Mean: } \bar{Y} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n Y_i}{n}$$

Next Up: R

